TRENT UNIVERSITY

TRENT INNOVATION BOOTCAMP · AGRICULTURE & AG-TECH

From indigenous ingredients to shared multicultural tables

A food box and recipe-learning app for households in Peterborough & the Kawarthas.

Tuesday, November 3rd 2026 | Team: Care Bears



Innovation Bootcamp presented by Trent University's Office of Research and Innovation and the Create Centre for Entrepreneurship

In collaboration with LAUNCH KAWARTHA · PRHC FOUNDATION · peterborough

Support by Intellectual Property Ontario · Prima IP · OCI · Angel Investors Ontario · mitacs · ecampus Ontario · CLEANTECH NORTH SOLUTIONS

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THE HOOK · THE BOOTCAMP CHALLENGE

How can we produce more protein with fewer resources, as conditions become less predictable?

CANADA · 2021

−38.5%

wheat harvest, after drought and extreme heat

Yields fell 33.3% and harvested area 7.7%

WHAT IT SHOWS

Canada has already seen how vulnerable production can be: one hot, dry season cut a staple crop by more than a third.

SO WE LOOKED FOR

Production systems that **use resources well** and **add diversity** to our food supply.

Statistics Canada, principal field crop production (Dec 2021)

THE OPPORTUNITY · BUILD ON WHAT ALREADY WORKS

Three Sisters: more protein per hectare

We don’t need to invent a new protein. Indigenous agricultural knowledge already offers a starting point.

Corn
gives the beans a natural trellis

Beans
fix nitrogen that feeds the soil

Squash
shades the soil and holds moisture

Plus Mnoomin (wild rice), a native grain from local lakes — the fourth staple in every CAFÉ box.

349 kg

of protein per hectare — more than the same crops grown separately on that land

15.86
people/ha/yr supplied with protein (vs ~13)

+24%
soil respiration; 54% less leftover nitrate



But growing more protein isn’t enough — these foods still have to reach everyday meals.

Mt. Pleasant, Ethnobiology Letters (2016); Kapayou et al., Agriculture and Human Values (2022)

THE PROBLEM · FROM FIELD TO FORK

The gap between the field and the fork

1 · THE KNOW-HOW GAP

Available isn't the same as familiar

99% → **51%**

see beans as healthy

eat them at least weekly

In an Ontario study (250 adults aged 65+, 49 in focus groups), unfamiliarity and not knowing how to prepare beans were leading barriers.

2 · THE VALUE GAP

Interest has to become a purchase

75% would pay a premium for local food

and

63% would pay more for origin transparency

Both are stated intentions, not actual purchases — the product has to be useful and worth its price.

CAFÉ's point of intervention: pair local heritage ingredients with practical cooking guidance and convenience — one small link that turns interest into habit, and habit into demand for local growers.

Guelph bean study, Nutrients (2019); PwC Canada, Voice of the Consumer (2025, n = 1,020)

OUR PRODUCT · HOW IT WORKS

Build your box. Meet your growers.

The CAFÉ app turns heritage staples into weeknight meals — and links every box to the people who grow it.

- Get inspired by multicultural recipes
- Learn home gardening and seed saving
- Customize and preorder your Indigenous food box

CAFÉ app
Scan to build your box



FROM FIELD TO TABLE

Secret sauce: prepaid, pooled orders = no inventory risk, steady demand for growers

1. **Choose & prepay in the app**
2. **Pool orders by ingredient**
3. **Buy from partner growers**
4. **Portion & pack locally**
5. **Deliver to pickup partners**
6. **Collect, scan & cook**

Planned pickup partners: The Main Ingredient · Jo Anne's Place · One Fine Food

OUR SOLUTION

Heritage foods, made easy to buy and cook

WHO IT'S FOR

First Nations & Indigenous households — P1 · Core
Trusted sources, family quantities, a fair price

Local-food & multicultural cooks — P1 · Core
Traceable food and recipes, incl. newcomers

Cottage & holiday cooks — P2 · Seasonal
Achievable recipes, easy arrival-day pickup

Food-gift buyers — P3 · Occasional
A meaningful, usable gift for someone who cooks

WHAT MAKES IT DIFFERENT

1 Discovery made easy

47% can't find ingredients

You get cornmeal, beans, squash and Mnoomin, with tested recipes

Why it matters discovery goes straight to a meal you can cook

2 Provenance you can trust

63% pay more for provenance

You get producer stories and knowledge from local knowledge holders

Why it matters know where food comes from, and who it supports

3 Meals that fit your life

$46 · no subscription

You get recipes matched to your household; prepaid local pickup

Why it matters a fair, predictable price; value flows to producers

OUR IP APPROACH & KNOWLEDGE STEWARDSHIP

Our differentiation combines the experience we build with trusted relationships we develop.

1 · BUILD OUR OWN ASSETS

CAFÉ brand, original app code and team-created content

2 · RESPECT CONTRIBUTED KNOWLEDGE

Permission, attribution and agreed usage terms for contributed recipes, stories and Indigenous knowledge

HelloFresh (Dec 2025); PwC Canada (2025, n = 1,020). Detail in A3 · IP: Proposed approach. Ownership and protection status to be confirmed. Detail in A6

BUSINESS & REVENUE MODEL

Simple pricing, positive margin per box

STARTER BASKET

$46

$39 ingredients + $7 preparation & pickup

- Pay per order, no subscription
- Add or remove standard packs
- Minimum order: $30 in ingredients

Where each $46 goes



- **Ingredients** $21.42
- **Packaging** $3.55
- **Pickup, payment, errors** $3.67
- **Contribution** $17.36

$28.64
direct cost per box

$150
fixed costs a month (web $50, marketing $100)

~9
boxes a month cover fixed costs

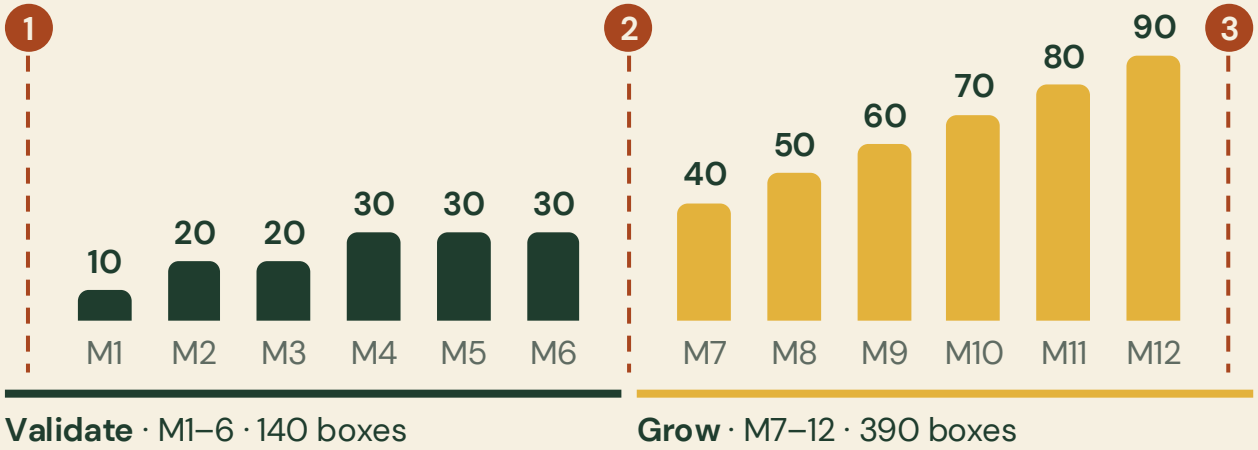
Next revenue streams (tested, not in the forecast): refills and add-on packs · cooking workshops · B2B dish and event pilots

Excludes transport and founder pay; four co-founders unpaid in Year 1. Cost detail in A6

FINANCIAL PROJECTIONS · CONTINGENCY PLAN

Year 1 plan, with a fallback at every gate

Target boxes per month · numbered markers are decision gates



Validate · M1–6 · 140 boxes

Grow · M7–12 · 390 boxes

$24.4K
Year-1 revenue

530
boxes sold

38%
contribution margin

$7.4K
Year-1 surplus*

1 LAUNCH

Plan $2,500 award; supply, packaging and pickup confirmed

If missed a smaller pilot with existing equipment and capped preorders

2 MONTH 6

Plan 140 orders, ~30% repeat in 90 days, ≥95% on-time-in-full

If missed 3 more months of validation; refine offer, price or pickup

3 MONTH 12

Plan 530 orders, $24.4K sales, first paid B2B pilot

If missed defer Year-2 expansion; focus on the strongest segment

*Before transport and founder pay. At any stage we pause a product or claim that risks trust. Detail in A7, A11

GO-TO-MARKET · 3-YEAR PLAN

Three years, one step at a time

1 YEAR 1
Validate demand

- Four recipe directions; baskets with QR recipe guides
- Home packing, prepaid batches, one pickup area
- Social demos and workshops; one paid B2B pilot

Gate: 530 orders, $24.4K sales, repeat demand

IF NOT MET
Defer expansion; focus on the strongest segment; narrow or stop if retests fail

2 YEAR 2
Expand selectively

- Pilot 2–4 ingredients as limited meal kits
- Test a qualified sourcing and logistics hub
- Evaluate one adjacent pickup cluster; Trent foodservice

Gate: core covers overhead and agreed pay

IF NOT MET
Expand one dimension at a time, or stay local; keep B2C as the core

3 YEAR 3
Longer-term options

- Replicate the proven fulfilment model
- Explore soup mix or broader menus
- Producer-led education; institutions, licensing

Gate: reliable service, positive operating cash flow

IF NOT MET
Freeze expansion if cash is short; protect delivery and refund commitments

THE ASK

$2,500 to launch our pilot

$800 · Equipment, setup and product testing

$800 · Marketing and sampling, Months 1–6

$300 · Website and software, Months 1–6

$600 · Working capital and contingency

BEYOND FUNDING

Mentorship, and introductions to Indigenous producers, knowledge holders and pickup partners.

Month 1 · first 10 paid boxes

Month 6 · 140 orders, ~30% repeat

Month 12 · 530 orders, B2B pilot

Thank you

CAFÉ app

Scan to build your box



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CLEANTECH NORTH SOLUTIONS

APPENDIX

RESEARCH & MARKET

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A2 Market sizing

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APPENDIX A1 · SUPPLY

Local Indigenous food ecosystem

Organization	What it does	Relevance to CAFÉ
Mnoomin harvesters: Curve Lake, Hiawatha, Alderville FN	Grassroots, community-based harvest and restoration of Mnoomin	Potential sourcing and knowledge partners
Curve Lake Community Garden	Grows the Three Sisters: corn, beans and squash	Potential source and education partner
Shki Maajitaawin Gitigaanan, Curve Lake FN	43,000 sq ft aquaponics: up to 250,000 lb tilapia and 100,000 lb produce a year	Indigenous-owned supplier to grocers and Graze & Gather
Black Duck Wild Rice, Pigeon Lake area	Processed wild rice	Planned wild rice supplier
Nogojiwanong Friendship Centre	Wiisinadaa: Let's Eat — nutrition and diabetes program, Peterborough	Potential community and education partner
Regional food sovereignty projects	White Corn Project (Six Nations); Three Sisters project and Kenhtè:ke Seed Sanctuary (Tyendinaga)	Learning network and seed sovereignty links

Team research (Burns, 2025; AAFC, 2021). Listing an organization does not imply an agreement

APPENDIX A2 · MARKET

Market sizing and assumptions

Bottom-up sizing

Tier	Calculation	Value / year
TAM	61,740 households × $8,659 average spend on food from stores	$534.6M
SAM	61,740 × 63% who'd pay more for provenance = 38,900 households × 4 boxes × $46	$7.2M
SOM	Year-1 plan: 530 boxes × $46	$24,380 (0.34%)

Assumptions: Canada-average grocery spend (StatCan, 2023) applied locally; 63% from PwC (2025); one box per quarter is a planning assumption to test in the pilot.

Local market

61,740
households, City & County

7,095
Indigenous residents

~18,000
seasonal residents

3M+
visitors a year ($277M reported)

StatCan SHS 2023 and 2021 Census; Peterborough County estimate; City of Peterborough (Apr 2026)

APPENDIX A3 · POSITIONING

Market evidence behind each differentiator

Differentiator	Customer value	Evidence
Easy cultural food discovery	Recipes built around a distinctive ingredient collection; discovery links straight to what you can buy and cook.	88% of Canadian Gen Z and millennials enjoy exploring cultural cuisines; 47% of Canadians say ingredient availability is a barrier to new dishes at home (HelloFresh, Dec 2025).
Tangible, trusted provenance	Verified sourcing, producer-approved stories, ingredient info and ordering in one place; agreed Indigenous partnerships give it substance.	63% would pay above-average prices for origin transparency; 1 in 5 would pay a 10%+ premium. Of non-local buyers, 39% cite limited access and 35% say local brands are hard to find (PwC, 2025, n = 1,020).
Personally relevant meals	AI matches preferences to tested recipes and available ingredients, with clear portions and preparation needs.	46% want products for specific health needs; 45% of health-conscious shoppers are comfortable asking AI to plan meals (PwC, 2025). AI personalized-nutrition market: $1.59B (2025) → $17.72B (2035), 27.4% CAGR.

APPENDIX A4 · COMPETITION

Competitive matrix

Feature	CAFÉ	HelloFresh	Goodfood	Odd Bunch	Graze & Gather	Samsung Food+
Physical food delivery	Planned	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Not seen
Multicultural recipes	Planned	Yes	Yes	Not seen	Not seen	Related
Meal personalization	Planned	Yes	Yes	Limited	Limited	Yes
AI menu personalization	Planned	Not seen	Not seen	Not seen	Not seen	Yes
Provenance & heritage focus	Planned	Related	Related	Related	Yes	Not seen
Indigenous-sourced experience	Planned	Not seen	Not seen	Not seen	Not seen	Not seen

Planned = concept-stage; Indigenous sourcing depends on verified partnerships. **Related / Limited** = partial overlap. **Not seen** = not established in the pages reviewed.

Proposed position: heritage-led ingredients + multicultural recipes + personalized guidance + coordinated fulfilment

APPENDIX A5 · COMPETITION

Competitor strengths and our response

Competitor	Evidence of strength	Our strategic response
HelloFresh	100+ weekly menu items (dinners, sides, desserts), dietary categories and protein swaps	Menu breadth is already well served; compete on a distinctive ingredient and heritage experience
Goodfood	500+ recipes in its library, including multicultural dishes and customizable proteins	Make the producer–ingredient–recipe connection central to the offer
Graze & Gather	96% of its offering comes from small producers; delivers to Peterborough and the Kawarthas	Close sourcing competitor whose heritage positioning overlaps ours — and a possible partner
Odd Bunch	One free substitution; extra substitutions at $0.99 each	Box flexibility alone won't set us apart; lead with recipe usefulness and curated discovery
Samsung Food+	Personalized seven-day meal plans, AI recipe adaptation and nutrition tracking	Our AI must connect reliably to actual ingredient supply and tested recipes

Sources: hellofresh.ca; makegoodfood.ca; grazeandgatherfood.ca; help.oddbunch.ca; samsungfood.com

APPENDIX A6 · INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY

IP assets, permissions & next steps

Asset / contribution	Proposed approach	Next step
CAFÉ name, logo and visual identity	Assess trademark protection for distinctive branding	Check name availability and confirm ownership of design assets
Original app code and interface assets	Document authorship and ownership; assess applicable copyright protection	Confirm founder/developer agreements and third-party licences
Original written guides, photos and videos	Document team-created material and permissions for external content	Maintain a content and permissions register
Contributed recipes and producer stories	Agree on permitted uses, attribution and any compensation	Obtain contributor agreements before publication
Indigenous knowledge and seed-saving education	Work with appropriate knowledge holders on consent, context and sharing boundaries; do not present shared knowledge as exclusive team IP	Agree on what may be shared, by whom and under what terms
AI-generated material	Review accuracy, provenance and platform terms; avoid assuming exclusive ownership	Establish a review process before publishing
Patents	No patent claim at this stage	Reassess only if a specific technical invention emerges

APPENDIX A7 · UNIT ECONOMICS

Direct cost per box: $28.64

Ingredients

Item	Size	Cost
Cornmeal	500 g	$2.50
Dry beans	250 g	$2.00
Wild rice (Black Duck Wild Rice)	250 g	$12.50
Whole squash	~1 kg	$4.00
Portioning loss	2%	$0.42
Subtotal		$21.42

$46.00 price − $28.64 cost = **$17.36 contribution (37.7%)**

Fixed: $50/month website & software + $100/month marketing & sampling

Packaging & fulfilment

Item	Basis	Cost
Food-grade pouches	3 × $0.60	$1.80
Product labels (EcomPack)	3 × $0.05	$0.15
Outer box	per box	$1.50
Order label & recipe QR	per order	$0.10
Pickup partner handling	per order	$2.00
Payment processing	2% of $46	$0.92
Replacements & errors	per order	$0.75
Subtotal		$7.22

3 pouches and 3 labels per box (squash ships whole) reconcile to the plan's $28.64. Excludes transport and founder pay.

APPENDIX A8 · FINANCIALS

12-month projection

M1–6 · Validate demand, then build repeat purchases

Month	Boxes	Sales	Var. costs	Surplus
1	10	$460	$286.40	$23.60
2	20	$920	$572.80	$197.20
3	20	$920	$572.80	$197.20
4	30	$1,380	$859.20	$370.80
5	30	$1,380	$859.20	$370.80
6	30	$1,380	$859.20	$370.80
M1–6	140	$6,440	$4,009.60	$1,530.40

M7–12 · Grow order density, build repeatable demand

Month	Boxes	Sales	Var. costs	Surplus
7	40	$1,840	$1,145.60	$544.40
8	50	$2,300	$1,432.00	$718.00
9	60	$2,760	$1,718.40	$891.60
10	70	$3,220	$2,004.80	$1,065.20
11	80	$3,680	$2,291.20	$1,238.80
12	90	$4,140	$2,577.60	$1,412.40
M7–12	390	$17,940	$11,169.60	$5,870.40

Year 1: 530 boxes · $24,380 sales · $15,179.20 variable costs · $1,800 fixed · **$7,400.80 surplus**

Surplus = sales − $28.64/box − $150/month fixed. Unpaid founders; excludes grants, B2B revenue and transport.

APPENDIX A9 · FUNDING

Use of the $2,500 award

Allocation

Item	Amount	Purpose
Startup & launch prep	$800	Equipment, setup, product testing, admin preparation
Marketing & sampling	$800	Funds the existing $100/month budget, M1–6
Website & software	$300	Funds the existing $50/month budget, M1–6
Working capital & contingency	$600	Bulk purchase timing, packaging stock, unexpected costs
Total	$2,500	Conditional on winning and permitted-use terms

Startup items ($1,000)

Item	Budget
Scales, sealer, storage, handling tools	$200
Registration & admin setup	$200
Label & operating-document review	$100
Recipe, portioning & packaging trials	$150
Checkout setup, signage & launch	$150
Total	$800

No award: smaller pilot with existing equipment and capped preorders. Unspent contingency is held as cash.

Roadmap: Year 1

Workstream	Months 1–6 · Validate demand	Months 7–12 · Stabilize and grow
Product	Test up to 9 Mexican, Vietnamese & Indigenous recipes; editable baskets with recipe QR guides	Improve favourites; add 1–2 recipes a month; leftover check-ins and opt-in refill prompts
Operations	Home repacking, founder labour, prepaid batches, one pickup area; ≥95% on-time-in-full by M6	Standardize packing; get partner quotes (producers, Graze & Gather); measure costs and capacity
B2C sales	Curious local cooks; $46 reference basket; 140 orders; ~30% 90-day repeat target	Grow via refills, referrals and grouped orders; 530 cumulative orders, $24,380 sales
Marketing	Instagram/Facebook demos; one local creator test; up to $100/month; track paid conversion	Cooking & refill workshops (prospects: Nourish, The Mount, Trent clubs); track orders per event
B2B & partners	Interview chefs, caterers and workshop budget owners (M4–6) on problems and budgets	One dish/event offer; ~8–10 buyer interviews; 1 paid pilot by M10–12; no base revenue assumed

APPENDIX A11 · GO-TO-MARKET

Roadmap: Years 2–3

Workstream	Year 2 (M13–24) · Expand selectively	Year 3 · Longer-term options
Product	Pilot 2–4 complementary ingredients as limited meal kits (M19–24), backed by costed recipes	Explore soup mix or broader menus after processing, shelf-life and market validation
Operations	Pilot sourcing and logistics with a qualified hub or distributor; part-time staff only if needed	Replicate the proven fulfilment model with reliable service and positive operating cash flow
B2C sales	Deepen repeat demand; evaluate one adjacent pickup cluster; expand only the strongest offer	Consider wider regional reach where each new area has viable density and capacity
Marketing	Repeat partner events and seasonal campaigns; scale winning collaborations and referrals	Extend producer-led education selectively, with agreed attribution
B2B & partners	Convert pilots into repeat orders; explore Trent foodservice; seek scheduled supply or menu deals	Explore institutions and licensing selectively, where procurement fit is demonstrated

Decision gates and contingencies

Checkpoint	Gate	If unmet
Launch: readiness	Conditional $2,500 award; home setup ready; supply, packaging and pickup confirmed first	Smaller pilot: existing equipment, capped preorders; delay if essentials aren't met
Month 6: demand	140 orders and $6,440 sales; ~30% 90-day repeat; ≥95% on-time-in-full	Extend validation 3 months; refine segment, offer, price or pickup; simplify
Month 12: model	530 orders, $24,380 sales; positive contribution after transport and any paid labour	Defer Year-2 expansion; focus on the strongest segment; narrow or stop if retests fail
M12–18: B2B	One paid B2B pilot by M12, then a reorder decision; partner terms confirmed	Keep B2C as the core; test a smaller dish/event package; separate sourcing from logistics
M18–24: expansion	Paid tests support bundles or kits; core covers overhead and agreed compensation	Expand one dimension at a time, or stay local; add staff only when demand funds it
Any stage: trust	Quality, traceability, accurate sourcing and cultural claims; cash for commitments	Pause the affected product or claim; freeze expansion; protect delivery and refunds

APPENDIX A13 · FUNDING

Funding and support pipeline

Source · timing	Potential support	Conditions and next step
Pitch award · Launch	$2,500, conditional: startup $1,000, marketing $600, software $300, contingency $600	Budget only if won and uses are permitted; hold unspent contingency as cash
Community Futures Peterborough · M1–6	Business advice, planning support, financing for working capital or equipment	Financing may be a repayable loan; borrow only with a repayment case
Trent & student entrepreneurship · M1–12	Competitions, mentoring, prototype help, introductions; research on demand or waste	Find the program owner; confirm eligibility and IP/data terms
Ontario & federal agri-food programs (e.g., Sustainable CAP) · M4–12	Market development, equipment, processing or collaboration support, deployed in Year 2	Verify fit, cost-share and approval-before-spending; a home repacker may not qualify
FedDev Ontario & partners · Year 2	Regional growth or productivity support once a scalable project exists	Check if direct, intermediary-delivered or repayable; excluded until approved
Research & community collaboration · M7–24	Scoped testing, facilities, expertise or joint educational activity	Start from a shared problem and named owner; research funds aren't startup cash

APPENDIX A14

Sources: problem and food systems

Problem and climate

- Statistics Canada (Dec 2021). Production of principal field crops, 2021
- Statistics Canada (2022). Wheat stocks and wheat-based food prices
- FAO (2025). Food Balance Sheets 2010–2023
- Hultgren, A., et al. (2025). Impacts of climate change on global agriculture accounting for adaptation. Nature, 642, 644–652
- FAO (Dec 2025). Renewable water availability per person down 7% in a decade
- FAO (2025). Disaster impacts on agriculture, 1991–2023

Indigenous food systems

- FAO & Alliance of Bioversity International and CIAT (2021). Indigenous Peoples' food systems
- FAO. Indigenous Peoples: food and knowledge systems
- Burns, H. (2025). Trent University research on Mnoomin restoration
- AAFC (2021). What We Heard: Indigenous agriculture and agri-food
- Nogojiwanong Friendship Centre: Wiisinadaa program

APPENDIX A15

Sources: market and competitors

Market and consumers

- Statistics Canada (2025). Survey of Household Spending, 2023
- Statistics Canada, 2021 Census: Peterborough City & County
- Peterborough County: seasonal resident estimate
- City of Peterborough (Apr 2026): visitors, $277M reported
- HelloFresh Canada, “Plate of the Nations” (Dec 2025)
- PwC Canada (2025). Consumer survey, n = 1,020
- Canadian Grocer (2026); InsightAce Analytic

Competitors and partners (Oct 2026)

- hellofresh.ca · makegoodfood.ca · help.oddbunch.ca
- grazeandgatherfood.ca · samsungfood.com
- Sobeys and Loblaws, Peterborough
- Common Ground Farm Box · Kawartha Food Share
- Black Duck Wild Rice · EcomPack (Ontario)
- Pickup: The Main Ingredient, Jo Anne’s Place, One Fine Food